

THE gathering

SIX WEEKS IN EPHESIANS

Who You Really Are

AGES 8 TO 12

*Deeper teaching. Bigger questions.
Real answers.*

The Gathering Kids

THE GATHERING CTX · CLEBURNE, TEXAS

For our partners, with gratitude

WHAT IS INSIDE

*Six weeks in Ephesians. One big question: who are you, really?
Read one week at a time. Argue with it. Ask the hard questions.
They have answers.*

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Chosen Before You Were Born

EPHESIANS 1:1 TO 14

Big Idea Before you took your first breath, God already chose you, loved you, and had a plan for you.

Memory Verse

*"He chose us in him before the foundation of the world,
that we should be holy and blameless before him."*

Ephesians 1:4

THE TEACHING

Imagine God looking at the universe before He even made it. Before the stars. Before the oceans. Before the first tree or animal or person. And in that moment, God thought about you.

Not just "people in general." YOU. Your name. Your face. Your personality. And He said: "I choose that one. That one is mine."

That's what Paul is telling us in Ephesians 1. God didn't wait to see if you would be good enough. He didn't wait to see if you would mess up. He chose you before you existed. He adopted you into His family. He blessed you with every spiritual blessing in heavenly places.

This means your identity is not based on what you do. It's based on what God has already done. You are chosen. You are adopted. You belong.

BUT WHAT IF SOMEONE SAYS...

"How could God choose you before you were born? That doesn't make sense."

God is not stuck in time like we are. He sees the past, present, and future all at once. Before He made the world, He already knew you and loved you. That's how big and amazing He is.

"Does God have favorites?"

God doesn't play favorites the way people do. He chose EVERYONE who would trust in Jesus. The invitation is open to all. But yes, if you are in Christ, you are deeply, personally, specifically loved by God.

TALK TOGETHER

- How does it feel to know God chose you before you were even born?
- What's the difference between earning something and being given something? Which one describes how we become God's children?
- If someone asked you "Who are you?", how would you answer based on what we learned today?

DO TOGETHER

Write each family member's name on a piece of paper. Under each name, write: "Chosen by God before the foundation of the world." Put these somewhere you'll see them this week (bathroom mirror, fridge, bedroom door).

DECLARE TOGETHER

I am chosen by God! I am adopted into His family! I am blessed with every spiritual blessing! My identity is not based on what I do. It is based on what God has done. I belong to Him!

PRAY TOGETHER

Father, thank You for choosing us before we were even born. Thank You that we don't have to earn Your love. Help us remember who we really are this week. In Jesus' name, Amen.

Once Far, Now Close

EPHESIANS 2:1 TO 22

Big Idea We were dead in sin and far from God, but Jesus made us alive and brought us close.

Memory Verse

"But God, being rich in mercy, because of the great love with which he loved us, even when we were dead in our trespasses, made us alive together with Christ." Ephesians 2:4 to 5

THE TEACHING

Paul uses a pretty intense word in this chapter: dead. Not "struggling." Not "kind of lost." Dead.

Before we knew Jesus, we weren't just making mistakes. We were spiritually dead. Like a phone with no battery. Like a plant with no water. We couldn't fix ourselves because dead things can't do anything.

But then comes the best two words in the Bible: BUT GOD.

But God, who is rich in mercy and great in love, made us alive. He didn't wait for us to get better. He came to us while we were still dead and raised us up. That's not something you can earn. That's called GRACE: getting something amazing that you didn't deserve.

And not only did He make us alive. He brought us close. We were far away from God, strangers to His family. But through the blood of Jesus, the wall came down. Now we belong. Now we're home.

BUT WHAT IF SOMEONE SAYS...

"Why did Jesus have to die? Couldn't God just forgive us?"

Sin is serious. It's not like breaking a small rule. It separates us from a holy God. Jesus took the punishment we deserved so we could be forgiven AND made right with God. His death was the price that brought us back.

"If we're saved by grace, does it matter how we live?"

Grace isn't permission to do whatever we want. Grace changes us from the inside. When you really understand what Jesus did for you, you WANT to live for Him. Not to earn His love, but because you already have it.

TALK TOGETHER

- What does it mean that we were "dead" before we knew Jesus? Why couldn't we save ourselves?
- What are the two words that change everything in this chapter? (Hint: "But God...")
- How does it feel to know you were brought close to God, not because you were good enough, but because of His mercy?

DO TOGETHER

Draw two circles on a piece of paper. Label one "FAR" and one "CLOSE." In the FAR circle, write or draw what life is like without Jesus (lonely, lost, broken). In the CLOSE circle, write or draw what life is like WITH Jesus (loved, alive, home). Draw an arrow from FAR to CLOSE and label it: "Jesus brought me here."

DECLARE TOGETHER

I was dead, but God made me alive! I was far away, but Jesus brought me close! I am saved by grace through faith. It is a gift from God. I did not earn it. I cannot lose it. I am alive in Christ!

PRAY TOGETHER

Father, thank You for the two greatest words: "But God." Thank You for making us alive when we were dead. Thank You for bringing us close when we were far away. Help us live like people who have been given new life. In Jesus' name, Amen.

The Secret Is Out

EPHESIANS 3:1 TO 21

Big Idea God's mystery is revealed: everyone who trusts Jesus is part of His family. And God can do way more than we can imagine.

Memory Verse

"Now to him who is able to do far more abundantly than all that we ask or think, according to the power at work within us, to him be glory..." Ephesians 3:20 to 21

THE TEACHING

Paul talks about a "mystery" in this chapter. But it's not a mystery like a detective story where nobody knows the answer. In the Bible, a mystery is something that WAS hidden but NOW has been revealed.

And the mystery is this: God's family is for EVERYONE. Not just one group of people. Not just the "good" kids or the "religious" families. Everyone who trusts Jesus becomes a full member of God's family. Same inheritance. Same love. Same access to the Father.

Then Paul prays one of the biggest prayers in the Bible. He prays that we would know how wide, long, high, and deep God's love is. That we would be filled with ALL the fullness of God. Not 10%. Not half. ALL of it.

And then he reminds us: God is able to do FAR MORE than anything we ask or even imagine. Your biggest dream for your life? God can do more. The thing you think is impossible? God can do more. You haven't asked for too much. You've probably asked for too little.

BUT WHAT IF SOMEONE SAYS...

"Why does the Bible call it a 'mystery' if we know the answer?"

A mystery in the Bible isn't something we can't know. It's something that WAS hidden and is NOW revealed. For thousands of years, people didn't fully understand God's plan. Now, through Jesus, the secret is out!

"Can God really do anything?"

God can do anything that is consistent with who He is. He can't lie or do evil because that would go against His nature. But when it comes to helping you, loving you, and doing amazing things through you? There's no limit.

TALK TOGETHER

- What was the "mystery" that Paul talks about? Why is it such good news?
- What does it mean to be "filled with all the fullness of God"? What would that look like in your life?
- If you really believed God could do "far more abundantly" than you could imagine, what would you ask Him for?

DO TOGETHER

Each person writes down the BIGGEST thing they can imagine God doing in their life or family. Put all the papers in a jar or box labeled: "God Can Do Far More." Keep it somewhere visible. Pray over it together. Watch what God does.

DECLARE TOGETHER

The mystery is out! I am part of God's family! I am filled with all the fullness of God! My God is able to do far more abundantly than everything I ask or imagine! I dream big because I serve a big God!

PRAY TOGETHER

Father, thank You that we are part of Your family. Fill us with all Your fullness. Help us understand how wide, long, high, and deep Your love is. Do far more in our lives than we could ever imagine. In Jesus' name, Amen.

Walk Like Who You Are

EPHESIANS 4:1 TO 32

Big Idea Because of who you are in Jesus, live like it. Take off the old. Put on the new. Let your actions match your identity.

Memory Verse

"Put off your old self, which belongs to your former manner of life... and put on the new self, created after the likeness of God." Ephesians 4:22, 24

THE TEACHING

For three chapters, Paul told us WHO WE ARE. Chosen. Adopted. Alive. Filled. Now in chapter 4, he says: "Therefore... walk worthy." Because of all that, LIVE like it.

Paul uses a picture of clothes. The "old self" is like dirty, worn-out clothes that don't fit anymore. They represent the old way of living: lying, anger, selfishness, mean words. But here's the thing: when you became a Christian, you got NEW clothes. The "new self" created after the likeness of God.

The problem is, some of us still have the old clothes hanging in our closet. We're saved, but we keep putting on the old stuff. Paul says: TAKE IT OFF. Stop wearing what doesn't belong to you anymore. Put on kindness. Put on truth. Put on patience. Put on forgiveness.

This isn't about being perfect. It's about your OUTSIDE matching your INSIDE. Your Monday matching your Sunday. Your actions matching who God says you are.

BUT WHAT IF SOMEONE SAYS...

"Why do I still do wrong things if I'm a Christian?"

Being saved doesn't mean you're instantly perfect. You're a new person on the INSIDE, but you're still learning to live like it on the outside. Every day you choose: will I wear the old clothes or the new ones? God gives you the power to choose right.

"What if I mess up?"

You will mess up. Everyone does. But messing up doesn't change who you are. You're still God's child. Confess it, receive forgiveness, and put the new clothes back on. God's grace is bigger than your mistakes.

TALK TOGETHER

- What are some examples of "old self" behavior? What are examples of "new self" behavior?
- Is there an area of your life where your actions don't match who God says you are?
- What does it mean to "not let the sun go down on your anger"? Why is that important?

DO TOGETHER

Get two pieces of paper. Label one "OLD SELF" and one "NEW SELF." On the old self paper, write things that don't belong anymore (lying, mean words, selfishness). On the new self paper, write what God wants instead (truth, kindness, generosity). Crumple up the old self paper and throw it away together. Keep the new self paper visible.

DECLARE TOGETHER

I walk worthy of my calling! I take off the old self. It has no power over me! I put on the new self, created after the likeness of God! I speak truth. I forgive quickly. I use my words to build people up. My actions match my identity!

PRAY TOGETHER

Father, thank You that we are new creations in Christ. Help us take off the old self and put on the new self every day. When we mess up, remind us of Your grace. Help our actions match who You say we are. In Jesus' name, Amen.

Copy Your Father

EPHESIANS 5:1 TO 21

Big Idea Imitate God like a child copies their dad. Walk in love. Walk in light. Be filled with the Spirit every day.

Memory Verse

"Therefore be imitators of God, as beloved children. And walk in love, as Christ loved us and gave himself up for us." Ephesians 5:1 to 2

THE TEACHING

Have you ever watched a little kid copy their mom or dad? They walk the same way. They talk the same way. They try to do everything just like them. That's what Paul is talking about here: BE IMITATORS OF GOD, as beloved children.

You don't imitate someone by trying really hard. You imitate them by being CLOSE to them. By watching them. By loving them. The more time you spend with God, the more you naturally start to act like Him.

Paul also says we are LIGHT. Not "in the light." We ARE light. Because Jesus, the Light of the World, lives in us. And light does two things: it reveals (shows what's hidden) and it shines (pushes back darkness). You don't argue with darkness. You just turn on the light.

And Paul tells us to be FILLED with the Spirit. Not once at church. Continuously. Every day. The Spirit is like an endless

reservoir of everything you need: love, joy, peace, patience, power. Your job isn't to fill yourself. Your job is to yield, to surrender, and let Him fill you.

BUT WHAT IF SOMEONE SAYS...

"How can I 'be light'? I'm just a kid."

Light isn't about how old you are or how much you know. Light is about WHO LIVES IN YOU. Jesus is the Light, and He lives in you. When you're kind, when you tell the truth, when you include someone who's left out, you're shining. Kids can shine just as bright as adults.

"What does it mean to be filled with the Spirit?"

When you trusted Jesus, the Holy Spirit came to live inside you. Being "filled" means letting Him have full control. It's not about getting MORE of the Spirit. It's about the Spirit getting more of YOU. Every day, you say: "God, I surrender. Fill me. Lead me."

TALK TOGETHER

- Who do you naturally imitate or copy? What makes you want to be like them?
- What does it look like to "walk in love" at school? At home? With your friends?
- How can you "be light" this week? Where is there darkness that needs your light?

DO TOGETHER

Turn off all the lights in a room. Sit in the darkness for a moment. Then have one person turn on a flashlight. Talk about how ONE light changes everything. The flashlight didn't argue with the darkness. It just turned on. You are that light. Where can you shine this week?

DECLARE TOGETHER

I am an imitator of God as His beloved child! I walk in love the way Jesus loved me! I am light in the Lord, and I walk as a child of light! I am filled with the Spirit every day, not just on Sundays! I shine bright because Jesus lives in me!

PRAY TOGETHER

Father, thank You that we are Your beloved children. Help us imitate You by staying close to You. Fill us with Your Spirit every day. Help us walk in love and shine as light in the dark places around us. In Jesus' name, Amen.

Stand Strong

EPHESIANS 6:1 TO 24

Big Idea You are in a real spiritual battle, but God has given you everything you need to stand. Put on His armor and don't back down.

Memory Verse

"Be strong in the Lord and in the strength of his might. Put on the whole armor of God, that you may be able to stand against the schemes of the devil." Ephesians 6:10 to 11

THE TEACHING

Paul ends his letter with something important: a warning and a promise. The warning? You are in a battle. Not a pretend battle. Not a video game. A real spiritual battle against a real enemy who wants to steal, kill, and destroy.

But here's the promise: God has already given you everything you need to win. He doesn't send you into battle empty handed. He gives you His own armor.

Think about a soldier going to war. They don't go in their pajamas. They put on armor and grab their weapons. Paul says that's what we do every day as Christians. We put on the armor of God: the belt of truth, the breastplate of righteousness, shoes of the gospel, shield of faith, helmet of salvation, and the sword of the Spirit (which is God's Word).

And here's the key word Paul uses over and over: STAND. He doesn't say run. He doesn't say hide. He says stand. Hold your ground. Don't back down. Why? Because Jesus already won the battle. You're not fighting FOR victory. You're standing IN victory that Jesus already secured.

BUT WHAT IF SOMEONE SAYS...

"Is the devil real? Isn't he just a cartoon character with horns and a pitchfork?"

The Bible says the devil is real, but he's nothing like cartoons show. He's a fallen angel who rebelled against God. He's sneaky, not silly. He uses lies, fear, and discouragement to attack us. But here's the good news: Jesus already defeated him. The devil is a defeated enemy. He can roar, but he can't win.

"Why do I need armor if God is protecting me?"

Great question! God DOES protect us, and the armor is HOW He protects us. It's His armor, not ours. We don't make it. We don't earn it. We put on what He provides. It's like a parent giving their kid a raincoat. The parent provides it, but the kid still has to put it on.

TALK TOGETHER

- Why does Paul tell us to "stand" instead of "fight" or "attack"? What does standing mean in a battle?
- Which piece of the armor do you think you need most right now? Why?

- How can you use the "sword of the Spirit" (God's Word) when you're feeling afraid, tempted, or discouraged?

DO TOGETHER

Make your own "Armor of God" together! Use paper, cardboard, or whatever you have to create each piece: a belt, breastplate, shoes, shield, helmet, and sword. As you make each piece, talk about what it represents. Label each one. Keep the armor somewhere visible as a reminder that you are equipped for battle!

DECLARE TOGETHER

I am strong in the Lord and in the strength of His might! I put on the whole armor of God! The belt of truth is fastened! The breastplate of righteousness is on! The shield of faith is raised! The helmet of salvation protects my mind! The sword of the Spirit is in my hand! I STAND and I do not fall! Jesus already won the victory and I stand in it!

PRAY TOGETHER

Father, thank You for giving us Your armor. Help us put it on every day. When the enemy attacks with lies, help us stand on the truth. When we feel afraid, remind us that You have already won. We are not fighting alone. We stand in the victory Jesus already secured. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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